
UNIT 1 PARTICIPATION AND EMPOWERMENT

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1.0 INTRODUCTION

Participation and empowerment are two important terms that form foundation of organisational development. These are two strategies that can be adopted by an organisation in order to increase motivation, morale and productivity of employees. They not only lead to individual development of the employees but also results in the overall development of the organisation. In this unit we will try to understand the concept of participation and empowerment. We will also discuss the elements and aspects of these strategies. The benefits of employing these two strategies and process will also be discussed. Further the relevance of role of manager in implementation of both these strategies will be focused on. Lastly the programmes and techniques utilised to promote these strategies will be highlighted.

1.1 OBJECTIVES

After reading this unit, you will be able to:

- Define participation and empowerment;
- Conceptualise participation and empowerment;
- Elucidate the benefits of participation and empowerment;
- Describe the process of participation and empowerment;
- Analyse the role of managers in implementation of participation and empowerment;
- Describe the factors determining participation and empowerment; and
- Elucidate the programmes and techniques to promote participation and empowerment.

1.2 PARTICIPATION

Participation is the mental and emotional involvement of persons in group situations that encourage them to contribute to group goals and share responsibility for them (Newstrom and Davis, 1993). Managers who adopt participation as a strategy encourage involvement of their subordinates in problem solving and decision making process. Though the manager still retains the ultimate responsibility, this strategy promotes job involvement amongst the employees. Three most important elements of participation are (i) involvement, (ii) contribution and (iii) responsibility.

- i) **Involvement:** The employee while participating in problem solving or decision making or achievement of a particular goal should feel involved at both mental and emotional levels. Thus participation does not merely mean task involvement, but ego involvement of the employee is also necessary. Participation without ego involvement of the employee is termed as '*Pseudoparticipation*'. The managers should thus be careful to ensure that the whole self of the employee is involved and just not his/her skills in performing the task.
- ii) **Contribution:** Participation encourages people to contribute their skills and resources to the successful completion of tasks. It provides the employee with empowerment to be creative and innovative while achieving the goals assigned to them. Participation does not mean consenting to a particular decision or problem solving strategy. In consenting, the manager has already come up with a decision or a strategy and merely seeks approval of the employees. But in participation the employees are involved and contribute to the whole process of decision making or problem solving right from the start.
- iii) **Responsibility:** Participation provides an opportunity to the employees to take responsibilities. This not only enhances self involvement but also increases self efficacy of the employees. Feeling of responsibility in turn will encourage the employees to be further involved and contribute to the achievement of the organisational goal.

Thus the above three elements of participation are interrelated at the same time extremely important for participation to be effectively implemented in an organisation.

Participation is especially effective when the superiors or managers do not possess enough information to solve a problem alone to make an important decision. In this case he/she can benefit from the expertise of the subordinates. It can also be used when the nature of the problem is unclear or vague. It can be beneficial in situations where the acceptance of the decision by the subordinates is critical to its effective implementation and is relevant to them and when subordinates are willing to exercise their own judgment and express their point of view. However participation is possible only when there is no urgency involved in decision making and problem solving.

1.2.1 Benefits of Participation

Participation results in number of benefits to the organisation.

- i) **Acceptance of and commitment towards organisational goals**

Participation will ensure the acceptance of and commitment towards organisational goals as the employee is able to identify and find relevance in his/ her context. The employee in this case might also be involved in the process of setting an organisational goal, thus enhancing participation on the part of the employee.

ii) **Smooth implementation of organisational change**

As the employee is a part of the whole process of bringing about the organisational change, the smooth implementation of organisational change is possible. The views and concerns of the employees also get expressed through right channels and his/ her insecurities are dealt with thus enhancing the implementation.

iii) **Improves productivity, morale, self esteem and motivation of employees**

Through participation, the employee is also exposed to varied knowledge and expertise. Further the opportunity to participate in important decisions and problem solving process enhances the morale, motivation and self esteem of the employee thus improving his/ her productivity.

iv) **Leads to increased job satisfaction and job involvement**

Participation boosts job satisfaction and job involvements as the employee has a feeling of responsibility and contribution to the achievement of organisational goals.

v) **Promotes organisational citizenship**

Due to high job satisfaction and job involvement combined with an opportunity to contribute to the organisational processes brings about the feeling of organisational citizenship in the employee.

vi) **It establishes better communication in the organisation**

Participation and communication are interrelated in an organisation as better communication will enhance participation and effective implementation of participation as a strategy will ensure better and open communication.

vii) **Employees experience increased awareness about the organisation's finances, goals and operations that allow them to make better suggestions**

To ensure effective participation in an organisation, it is extremely important that relevant information with regard to finances, goals, operations etc is provided to the employee. This not only ensures effective decisions making and problem solving but also makes employee more aware.

1.2.2 The Process of Participation

Depending on the situation, whether, it demands problem solving, decision making or achievement of a particular task the participation programme can be launched. Once this programme is launched, it is important to ensure that the employees feel involved, both mentally and emotionally, have adequate scope and freedom to contribute and feel responsible towards the outcome of the activity. This in turn will ensure higher output, better quality and creative suggestions, acceptance of change and a conflict and stress free environment.

1.2.3 Factors Related to Success of Participation

However, success of participation will depend on varied factors.

i) **Adequate time should be available before participation is encouraged**

As the employees will require sufficient time in order to come up with a suitable suggestion or strategy. Thus participation cannot be used in emergency situations.

ii) **Consider benefits of participation before hand**

It is also important to consider before hand that the benefits of participation outweigh the costs involved. Only then participation can be termed as effective.

iii) **Ensure employee view participation**

Care should be taken to ensure that the employee view the process of participation positively at the same time find it interesting and significant.

iv) **To tap the Trade union attitude towards participation**

Even the attitude of trade unions in a particular organisation need to be focused and worked upon before encouraging participation.

v) **Ensure open communication amongst employees**

It is extremely important to promote open communication amongst the employees and between superiors and employees in order to promote participation. As without such a condition the employees will hesitate or fail to communicate their suggestions and view points. The employees should not feel threatened to express a particular view or suggestion.

vi) **Orient employees about goal of participation**

The employees should be oriented with regard to the goal and area of participation. So that they do not violate the area of job freedom of any other department or employee.

1.2.4 Programmes to Promote Participation

Various programmes can be used in order to promote participation amongst employees. These are discussed below:

Participative and Consultative Management

The organisation and especially the managers involved in promoting participation should adopt both participative and consultative management.

Participative management means that sufficient strategies, programmes and practices are employed in order to empower the employees and encourage participation amongst them.

Consultative management means that the superiors or managers provide adequate information, support and motivation to their subordinates to come up with suitable suggestions. Thus before participation is employed it is important that the organisation creates conducive environment for successful implementation.

Suggestion Programmes

These are formal plans strategised by the organisation to promote expression of suggestions and view points amongst the employees. Certain awards and prizes are also given to best suggestions. This does not merely mean making available a suggestion box at cafeteria or work place. But the organisation should have a concrete plan to ensure that large number of employees do contribute their suggestions to relevant issues regarding the organisation.

Quality Circles

Quality circles are a group of people who discuss and develop solutions issues that

relate to quality, productivity or costs. These circles meet regularly in order to generate suggestions with regard to varied issues. They provide employees with opportunities to personal development and feeling of achievement.

Total Quality Management (TQM)

Various organisations adopt TQM in their organisations in order to involve their employees in continuous improvement of their operations. Utmost importance is given to quality of product and services under TQM. As TQM is a formal programme that requires direct participation of each employee, it might be necessary to provide the employees with training with regard to the concept and implementation of TQM.

Self Managing Teams

Self Managing Teams or self directed teams can also be used to promote participation in organisations. In these teams there is no external supervision carried out. The team members can carry out their activities implement decisions and evaluate results on their own. This ensures participation of team members and as there is no supervision the members develop a sense of responsibility towards the functioning of the team and achievement of the team objective and are empowered in the process.

Survey Feedbacks

In survey feedback data about an organisation or one of its departments is collected with the help of a questionnaire and feed back is provided. This data is then used to identify problems in an organisation and develop suitable intervention strategies to deal with the problem.

Survey feedback enhances participation from employees at various hierarchical levels. The participation is encouraged amongst employees right from planning stage of survey feedback to the intervention development stage.

Search Conferences

These are conferences are organised for a duration of two to three days and is attended by twenty five to thirty employees. Employees for participation in such conferences are selected based on their potentialities, knowledge and expertise. The conference constitutes of plenary sessions as well as group discussions.

Search conferences can boost participation amongst the employees as they are encouraged to take part in such conferences and provide suggestions and possible solution to the impending problems in the organisation.

Self Assessment Questions

- 1) Explain how lack of contribution and responsibility on part of the employee can affect participation.

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- 2) Highlight factors that determine the success of participation.

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- 3) Explain Total Quality Management and quality circles as programmes to promote participation.
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1.3 EMPOWERMENT

In order to implement empowerment in an organisation, it is extremely important to understand what it is. Empowerment can be described as a condition that enables people to feel competent and in control, energized to take initiatives and persist at meaningful tasks. It is a part of progressive change witnessed in today's corporations.

One of the bases of empowerment is its view of power as it considers power to be something that can be shared by everyone in flatter and more collegial structures rather than considering power to be something to be held only at higher levels in the traditional organisational structures. It is thus important to distinguish empowerment from power.

Though power is one way in which activities and tasks can be enforced and performed in an organisation; it lies with certain people who act as authorities in exercising it. Where as in the process of empowerment a conducive environment is created in order to make people self sufficient and enable to achieve their greatest potentiality and contribute to the development of the organisation.

Empowerment can be categorised in to two, (i) structured empowerment and (ii) flexible empowerment. **Structured empowerment** provides guidelines to the employees about what exactly needs to be done. These guidelines help the employees solve problems and make decisions immediately without waste of time. This also enables managers to retain basic control over the procedure and the situation.

On the other hand **flexible empowerment** allows employees discretion to take decision and solve problems directly. A very broad guideline and limitations might be made available by the management to the employees. Further, suitable training in this case may also be provided to the employees.

Empowerment can come from within individual, from peers or from superiors. An individual can empower oneself by initiating personal actions to develop high self perception and enhance self motivation.

To empower oneself, it is extremely important to put in efforts and be willing to take on additional responsibilities, employ creative strategies in problem solving and set higher goals in accordance with one's potentialities.

Empowerment from colleagues and co workers can have an immense impact on the work related behaviour and performance of an individual. Respect, acceptance, encouragement, positive criticism and cooperation from colleagues and coworkers

can not only encourages the cohesiveness at the work set up but increases self perception at work and enhances achievement of individual and organisational goals.

One of the most important sources of empowerment is that from superiors. The empowering superior creates a conducive environment to enable empowerment of the individual. This can be done by providing complex tasks, challenging activities, sharing information, open communication, delegation of power, and providing concrete and positive criticism.

1.3.1 Benefits of Empowerment

Organisations have realised the benefits of developing and empowering their employees. Some of the benefits are listed as follows:

Empowerment brings about positive self perception

Three important concepts under self perception are self concept, self esteem and self efficacy. Self concept can be defined as how we view ourselves, self esteem is how we feel about our own worthiness and self efficacy is our perception about our ability to perform. A positive self perception will encourage an individual to set higher goals for one self, accept challenging tasks and enhance goal achievement.

Empowerment enhances motivation

Empowered people are better focused and are more committed to their goals. They are intrinsically motivated as their self perception is high.

Empowerment encourages active problem solving

Empowered individuals are more flexible in behaviour and try alternative paths when they are blocked and are eager to take new initiatives.

Empowerment alters expectations:

Since empowerment leads to overall development of the employees and their potential, the organisations can alter their expectations about productivity and performance of the employee. Thus the employees can be provided with challenging and complex tasks and organisations can expect them to carry out these tasks with high motivation, interest and enthusiasm.

1.3.2 The Process of Empowerment

There are two main aspects of process of empowerment, namely, (i) the removal of conditions of powerlessness and (ii) enhanced job related self efficacy. These lead to the perception of empowerment amongst the employees.

To remove the conditions of powerlessness in employees it extremely important to bring about a change in the overall power distribution in the organisation. In this regard a participative view should be accepted instead of an autocratic view. A downward flow of power and authority might not be effective in order to bring about empowerment in an organisation.

Managers play the most important role in empowering employees. Thus, it is important that the managers cultivate suitable leadership and communication skills and be open to sharing of power with their subordinates. Along with change in the processes and structures of the organisations, the leadership style employed in the organisation should also be focused on, so as to make it more inclusive and democratic, to create an environment suitable for development of empowerment amongst the employees.

A reward system that recognises the independent and group contributions of the employees and that which identifies creative and innovative ideas of employees should be implemented in the organisation. Further the job of the employee should be modified to make it more interesting, challenging and innovative.

To enhance job related self efficacy four broad aspects can be focused on, that is job mastery, role models, reinforcement and support. Employees can be empowered by providing them with an opportunity to develop mastery over their jobs. This can be done by providing them with suitable training, mentoring, coaching and career management and development opportunities.

Certain role models can also be provided to these employees. These role models can be the successful or productive employees of the organisation. Also certain younger employees can be paired with older and more experienced employees under mentoring programmes so as to provide the younger employees with guidance and support in the organisation. These older employees will not only serve as role models but will also ensure effective adjustment of the younger employee to the new environment of the organisation.

Reinforcements ranging from praise, verbal feed back to rewards can also be used in order to motivate an employee to work effectively and develop empowerment. It is also important to provide employees with psychological, emotional and social support in order to develop empowerment. This will lead to perception of empowerment amongst the employees. The employee will become competent to not only carry out his/her tasks effectively but with innovation and confidence. He/she will develop high value for himself/ herself. Will find the job more meaningful and will be able to use his/ her potentialities to the fullest.

1.3.3 Determinants of Empowerment

Various aspects need to be taken in to consideration before implementing empowerment. It is necessary to thoroughly understand the nature and the current environment in the organisation before empowerment is introduced. One reason why successful implementation of empowerment may fail is when the organisational culture is not conducive to its implementation. The organisational culture thus needs to be changed and modified before implementation of empowerment.

A culture of continuous learning and support needs to developed in an organisation. Empowerment requires a culture of trust and collaboration. The concept of OCTAPACE (Openness, Confrontation, Trust, Authenticity, Pro-action, Autonomy, Collaboration and Experimentation) has been proposed as the ethos for empowerment (Pareek, Udai, 2008).

Employees vary in their degree of empowerment. Some seek more responsibility and others less. Thus while implementing empowerment the individual differences amongst the employees needs to be taken in to consideration.

In order to promote empowerment amongst employees, it is important to first ensure that the concept of empowerment is understood by the employees and they have a positive attitude towards it. Further they might also need help in developing suitable skills to be empowered. Sense of confidence should be developed amongst the employees.

Before empowerment is implemented it is extremely important to focus on the present organisational strategy and goals. After this is considered then this strategy can be

safely implemented as, if it does not fit with the organisational strategy then the whole process of empowerment will be a futile exercise.

Technological advancement in an organisation can also be one of the determinants of empowerment in an organisation as it may actually facilitate its implementation and promotion.

1.3.4 Characteristics of Empowered Organisation

Following characteristics are observed in the empowered organisation:

- 1) Flat organisational hierarchy for equal distribution of power and opportunity to participate in problem solving and decision making.
- 2) Stress on quality of performance rather than quantity.
- 3) Facilitation and promotion of open communication amongst employees and management.
- 4) Employees encouraged and given chance to make personal contribution to the tasks on hand so as to promote development and empowerment.
- 5) High employee awareness in terms of individual and organisational goals.
- 6) An organisational culture that is cooperative and supportive and purposeful rather than problem and blame oriented.
- 7) Employees' satisfaction given utmost importance.
- 8) The processes of recruitment and selection are focused on, in order to hire employees who could possibly adjust well to the environment in the organisation.
- 9) Suitable opportunities for training and career development are provided.

1.3.5 Techniques for Empowerment

There are quite a few effective techniques for empowering employees and these are presented below:

Open Book Management

This technique not only results in empowerment of the employee but also leads to financial benefits to the organisation. The technique focuses on developing an understanding about financial aspects about the organisation amongst its employees so as to help them understand the organisational performance. The employees are then encouraged to set high performance standards in order to achieve high profitability thus providing the employee an opportunity to directly contribute to the achievement of the organisational goal and success. This also leads to effective participation.

Job Rotation, Job Enlargement and Job Enrichment

These three techniques can be effectively used to empower the employees. Job rotation involves time to time assignment of a completely new task and job activity, different from the actual work activity carried out by the employee on regular basis.

In job enlargement an employee is given wider variety of duties and tasks to perform so as to reduce his/ her monotony and make the work activity more interesting.

And under job enrichment, the focus is on the depth of the job. That is, the employee is given more control, responsibility and discretion over the work activities that he/ she carries out. This ensures complete job involvement on part of the employee.

Self Managing and Cross Functional Teams

These two types of team have already been discussed under the unit on team. They can be used effectively in order to develop empowerment in employees.

Self managing teams provide the employees with an opportunity function at his/ her own terms and take responsibility for the task performed. Where as, cross functional teams provides a chance to interact with team members who possess diverse skills and expertise which provides the employees with opportunity to learn.

Delegation

Empowerment in an employee can also be developed with the help of effective delegation. However, care needs to be taken to delegate work according to the potentialities of the employee. A systematic delegation should be applied here where the complexity of the work assigned to employee increases progressively. The delegator should also ensure the completion of work by regularly monitoring the progress, though care needs to be taken to avoid interference so as to provide the employee with a chance to take responsibility and work with his/ her full potential.

Involvement in Policy Making

Empowerment can also be developed by involving the employees in policy- making process of the organisation. This will provide the employees with sense of respect and he/ she will feel valued. This in turn will enhance the self esteem of the employee.

Self Assessment Questions

- 1) Discuss in detail the determinants of empowerment.

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- 2) What are the characteristics of empowered organisation?

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- 3) What are the various techniques of empowerment?

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- 4) Explain open book management and delegation as techniques of empowerment.

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1.4 ROLE OF MANAGERS IN PARTICIPATION AND EMPOWERMENT

Managers play the most important role in the implementation of participation and empowerment in an organisation. Various issues need to be dealt with when we focus on the role of managers. Though the benefits of promoting participation and empowerment amongst employees are quite obvious, there might be some resistance amongst managers in its application. This can be due to varied reasons discussed as follows:

Vague understanding of participation/empowerment

Some managers might not be clear about the concept of participation/empowerment, what it means and how it is to be implemented. This can interfere with the process on empowerment. Thus it is extremely important that suitable training regarding participation/empowerment is provided to the managers before it is introduced in the whole organisation.

Lack of skills

A manager might resist participation/empowerment or may not be able to successfully implement them due to lack of skills. He/ she may not possess suitable leadership and communication skills necessary for such implementation. The managers thus need training and organisational support with regard to this aspect. Further care can be taken while hiring managers so as to select managers who would be in position to empower the employees and ensure their effective participation.

Habit

Sometimes it is difficult for managers to promote participation/empowerment just because during the previous years they have been trained otherwise to delegate and use authority and power. Thus they may not be able to adjust to the sudden shift towards participation/ empowerment. In this case, positive attitude towards participation/ empowerment and its practices should be developed amongst the managers.

Insecurity

Many times managers may also feel insecurity about implementing participation/ empowerment due to fear of losing control over the employees. This can also be dealt with by providing training programmes and workshops so as to make managers better aware.

Pragmatism

Managers recognise the fact that participation/ empowerment however beneficial, might not be a solution to all the problems in an organisation and might not be suitable in certain situations. Thus they might not be completely convinced about the effectiveness of participation/ empowerment.

In this situation the managers need to be informed that if properly managed, participation/ empowerment can be of great benefit and that an overall culture of participation/ empowerment will greatly benefit the development of employees and the organisation as a whole.

It thus becomes a duty of the top level management to train, develop and empower the managers in an organisation before participation and empowerment is implemented

at other levels. The managers should be encouraged to play a role of a counselor or a coach who is sensitive to the problems of the employees and is always there to help and support in any circumstances. He/ she can be developer of talent and potentiality at the same time creator of goals and challenges. All this is again a challenging task for a manager as he/ she has to be a leader at the same time when other roles are being played.

Focus on individual differences

Managers also need to focus on individual differences. Individual differences will exist in ways each employee can be encouraged to participate or be empowered. As certain employees seek active participation and some may not. While some employees can be easily empowered within short duration of time, others may require extra support and help on behalf of the manager and other superiors. This might also differ depending on the age, gender, education, position and other demographic and socio- cultural aspects of the employees. These two strategies should thus be employed after due consideration of individual differences amongst the employees.

Kouze and Posner have suggested **five leadership practices** for managers that can help them in becoming effective managers.

- i) **Firstly**, the managers need to make the tasks assigned to the employees more challenging and they should be constantly in search of opportunities for such challenges. Further they should encourage experimenting and risk taking amongst employees in dealing with tasks at hand.
- ii) **Secondly**, it is important that the manager envisages a shared vision. The objectives are set in collaboration with the employees and are to be collectively achieved.
- iii) **Thirdly**, the manager should facilitate active participation amongst the employees and encourage them to work as a team and be supportive to each other.
- iv) **Fourthly**, the manager should serve as a role model to the employees.
- v) **Lastly**, the manager should recognise individual contributions and reinforce accomplishments.

Self Assessment Questions

- 1) Explain how lack of skills and insecurity can discourage managers from employing participation and empowerment.

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- 2) Discuss five leadership practices that can make managers effective.

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1.5 LET US SUM UP

Thus we can sum up that participation and empowerment are two significant strategies in organisational development. The most important outcomes of these strategies are acceptance of change on behalf of employees and enhanced performance as a result of goal oriented behaviour. Further they also promote awareness about the organisation, its structure, process and practices and also increase involvement of the employees in the goal achievement process of the organisation. Participation and empowerment also enhance organisational citizenship. The benefits of adoption of these two practices may not be immediate, though in long term, it will result in a highly positive organisational culture and well developed human resource.

Participation is not restricted only to management, but is extended to the employees at all levels in an organisation. To empower is to give power and this is done by providing an employee with authority to participate, make decisions, and contribute their ideas. In a way both these terms are interrelated as participation enhances empowerment and empowerment encourages participation.

However, utmost care needs to be taken before they are implemented in terms of organisational culture, attitude, managerial role and nature of organisation etc. But if implemented suitable the benefits of these two strategies can be observed for a long period of time and will greatly benefit the overall development of the organisation.

1.6 UNIT END QUESTIONS

- 1) Describe participation and empowerment and discuss their.
- 2) What factors need to be taken in to consideration before implementation of empowerment?
- 3) Describe the process of participation and empowerment.
- 4) Describe the significance of role played by managers in implementation of Empowerment.
- 5) Highlight the characteristics of empowered organisation.
- 6) Explain the programmes that be carried out for implementing participation and empowerment.

1.7 SUGGESTED READINGS

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UNIT 2 TEAM AND TEAMWORK

Structure

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- 2.2 Team
 - 2.2.1 Stages of Team Development
 - 2.2.2 Types of Team
 - 2.2.3 Team Activities
 - 2.2.4 Creating High Performance Team
- 2.3 Teamwork
 - 2.3.1 Problems Affecting Team Work
 - 2.3.2 Enhancing Team Work
- 2.4 Team Intervention Strategies
- 2.5 Let Us Sum Up
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2.0 INTRODUCTION

Work is becoming more and more complex day by day with technological advances and complex structure and processes in organisations. These factors have lead to varied complex problems. In order to deal effectively with this situation it is extremely important that teams are employed. Teams can be effectively used to carry out diverse tasks, solve problem, make decisions and implement them. However immense care has to be taken in order to build a team and ensure its smooth functioning. A very large team can make it very difficult for the team, members to coordinate, communicate and land on a single decision. Various types of teams can be used depending on the task on hand and the problem faced by the organisation. It is also extremely important to identify the problems that can occur during the functioning of the team and suitable intervention are carried out to ensure their smooth functioning.

In this unit we will try to understand concept of team and teamwork. The characteristics of high performing teams will be also discussed. The unit will also highlight activities carried out by teams. The problems interfering with effective team work will also be explained along with ways of promoting effective team work.

2.1 OBJECTIVES

After completing this unit, you will be able to:

- Define team and team work;
- Describe high performing teams;
- Explain activities carried out by teams;
- Elucidate the barriers to effective teamwork; and
- Analyse the ways of enhancing teamwork.

2.2 TEAM

Team can be explained as cumulative effort of a number of individuals. It is different from a group in number of ways. The members of a team are accountable for each others performance. Teams can be termed as more effective than individuals because the employee skills are better utilised in teams. Teams are flexible and enhance and facilitate employee involvement and participation and also lead to increase in motivation of the employees. A team is more effective in problem solving, decision making and achievement of organisational goals as compared to an individual. Teams can be used when many perspectives are needed and acceptance of decision is critical, when the problem or task in hand is complex and diverse suggestions are required and when risk involved is high.

Team can be categorised in to two: (i) Family group and (ii) special group. Family group is a permanent team consisting of a superior and several subordinates whereas the special group is a temporary team constituted to tackle specific tasks, as for example ad hoc committees and newly formed groups.

Teams are significant for various reasons. Changes in norms and values of a team have a direct impact on the behaviours of team members and such changes are long lasting and immediate. Thus teams can be effectively utilised to positively influence the behaviours of its team members. Certain tasks that are complex can be conveniently dealt with, with the help of a team that constitutes individuals with diverse skills.

The cumulative effort of the team members results in a synergy. Further working as a team enhances individuals need for social interaction, recognition, and belongingness. It also serves as a support system while the individuals are facing problems in dealing with tasks on hand.

A team can be distinguished from a group. A group is two or more people who regularly interact and influence each other; however, members of a group see themselves as individual entity and produce individual output. A team is a type of group with a common objective, whose collective and coordinated efforts result in a common output. A team may be described as a group but not every group can be described as a team. The distinction between team and group is presented in the table below:

Table: Difference between teams and groups

Parameters	Teams	Groups
Performance	Depends on both individual and collective contributions of the team members	Depends on work of individual members.
Accountability	Individual and mutual	Individual
Goals	Common goals and commitment to achievement of goal.	Common goals.

2.2.1 Stages of Team Development

A team goes through various stages of development which can be categorised in to four main headings namely, (i) forming, (ii) storming, (iii) norming and (iv) performing.

These stages are discussed below:

- i) **Forming:** Once the team has been put together, the members may know or may not know each other. At this stage the members interact and get to know each other better. A rapport is established amongst the members which is extremely important for the succeeding stages of team development as well as for the achievement of the team goal. Once the members get to know each other better, they discuss about the team tasks and goals.
- ii) **Storming:** As the name suggests this stage is that of discussion and arguments about the team goal and making plans to achieve it. The team members also compete at this stage for status, position and control in the team. At this stage tension between the team members might also be created. It is extremely important for the leader to coordinate amongst the members and manage the team members during this stage as it is most crucial for efficient performance of the team.
- iii) **Norming:** At this stage to some extent, balance prevails after the stage of storming. Now the team is in position to work together. It is more settled as the team members are already aware about the roles that they are expected to play and there is some kind of a consensus with regard to the functioning of the team. The team is now ready to collectively work towards achievement of the goal.
- iv) **Performing:** Through the earlier three stages, the team develops and the members also develop positive interpersonal relationship with each other and are more comfortable working with each other. At this stage the team is ready to deal with complex challenges and achieve the team goal.

A fifth stage might be added to this depending on whether the team is permanent or temporary. In case it is temporary then the last stage is Adjourning where the team members have achieved the team goal and are now no more required to work as a team and thus the team is adjourned. At this stage the team members might be involved in winding up activities of the team.

2.2.2 Types of Team

As per the needs of the organisations various types of teams can be employed. Some of these types include (i) problem solving team (ii) cross functional team (iii) Self managing team (iv) virtual team. These are discussed in detail below:

- i) **Problem Solving Teams:** As the name suggests the main purpose of this team is focusing on the problem and coming up with a suitable solution. The members of this team meet regularly to examine work related problems.

Quality circles can also be formed under this type of team that mainly discuss and develop solutions to issues that relate to quality, productivity or costs. For the quality circles to be effective the members and the leader need adequate training in group dynamics, information gathering and problem solving techniques.

- ii) **Cross- Functional Teams:** The speciality of this type of team is that it consists of members representing different departments or units in the organisation. For example this type of team may consist of managers from different departments in the organisations like finance, human resource, production etc. However, a problem can occur in these teams due to failure in communication across functions, referred to as 'functional silos'. 'Functional silos' occurs when the employees from a particular department are well aware about their own work

activity but are poorly involved in and have weak idea about activities of other departments.

- iii) **Self Managing Teams:** Also called as self directed teams, this is a high involvement team in which there is no external supervision carried out on the functioning and activities of the team. The team is empowered to carry out their activities, implement decisions and evaluate results on their own.
- iv) **Virtual Teams:** Due to technological advancement it is possible for employees in organisations to work together as a team from different locations. Such teams are referred to as virtual teams in which the members from different locations are electronically linked together via networked computers. This type of teams not only saves time but also expenses of travelling from different places. However members should be well trained in using computers.

2.2.3 Team Activities

A team may be constituted to carry out a number of activities in an organisation. These activities include (i) Advising (ii) Innovating (iii) Promoting (iv) Developing (v) Organising (vi) Producing (viii) Inspecting (ix) Maintaining and (x) Linking are listed as follows:

- i) **Advising:** A team may be constituted in order to identify and understand a particular problem or issue in an organisation so as to provide the management with suitable advice. Advice may also be given with regard to organisational development, employee well-being, technological advancement etc.
- ii) **Innovating:** One of the activities carried out by teams is innovating that is brainstorming and engaging in systematic discussion and coming up with innovative ideas about products, advertising, strategies etc.
- iii) **Promoting:** A team may also be involved in promotional activities. These promotional activities may be related to launching a new product or a particular strategy or programme like health, safety, discipline etc. in the organisation.
- iv) **Developing:** A team may be part of developing a new product or strategy. It may also be involved in developmental activities meant for employees or organisation as a whole. But mainly it may be involved in planning the developmental activities and also its implementation and follow-up.
- v) **Organising:** Another activity of a team is organising. A team may be constituted to organise seminars, conferences, events and other programmes in an organisation. It may also be involved in organising training and development programmes. Further, they may also contribute to organising varied human resource functions like selection, recruitment, performance appraisal etc.
- vi) **Producing:** A team may also be involved in the production activities of the organisation. The production may be with regard to the existing products or a newly launched product. In either case a team facilitates the overall functioning of that particular department by providing help to deal with complex problems and making the whole process fast and accurate.
- vii) **Inspecting:** A team may also be formed in order to inspect a particular problem, accident or a strategy. The team members here would be mainly involved in evaluation and analysis of the task in hand.
- viii) **Maintaining:** A team is also utilised in order to maintain discipline, safety rules

and strategies in an organisation. They may also be involved in maintaining positive attitude, high morale, high motivation and overall maintenance of organisational citizenship amongst the employees.

- ix) **Linking:** A team also serves as a link between varied groups in an organisation, like, management and employees or two or more formal or informal groups of employees. It mainly functions here to bridge the gap between the two or more groups and maintain cordial communication and intergroup relationship.

Thus there are varied types of activities that a team can utilise to perform. A single team may perform one, many or all of the activities depending on the nature of the organisation, problem faced and the demands of the situation.

2.2.4 Creating High Performing Team

A high performing team in an organisation results in high productivity and swift achievement of organisational goals. Any organisation should focus on developing high performing teams in their organisations. Such teams have special characteristics that enhance their team work. Such teams have strong core values that guide their behaviour, performance and attitudes towards achievement of team goals. There also exists amongst team members a shared sense of purpose to achieve the objectives. Such teams set performance standard for themselves on the basis of which the performance is regularly evaluated and feedback is taken in to consideration. Frequently high performing teams comprise of people with diverse skills and engage highly in lateral and creative thinking. In order to develop high performing teams in organisations following measures can be adopted.

- i) **Setting high performance standards:** It is important that the management in an organisation recognises certain teams and set high performing standards or goals for these teams. It is also important that these standards should be clear and specific so that they drive the team members towards achieving them. It is not enough just to set these standards but there also needs to be suitably communicated to the respective teams.
- ii) **The first team meeting:** The first team meeting here is crucial as during this meet the rapport needs to be established not only between the management and team members but also amongst the team members. In this meet the specific goals and expected performance of the team are to be clearly stated. This meet should set ground for the team to carry on with the assigned task.
- iii) **Creating a sense of urgency:** Certain time limit for the achievement of goal needs to set and communicated to the team members in order to create a sense of urgency and commitment amongst the members. The members should also be encouraged to be involved in planning and setting smaller goals with time limit in order to efficiently achieve the final objective assigned to them.
- iv) **Select members with right skill:** In the process of team building, care needs to be taken to include members with diverse skills. It is also important to select members with effective communication, interpersonal and leadership skills. This has to be done keeping in mind the goal set for the team.
- v) **Establishing clear rules and norms for team behaviour:** The team members should be informed about the limitations of their work activity and expected team behaviour. This can also be communicated in the first meet so that the expectations of the team members are clarified before they get in to the working mode.

Keep the team members aware and informed. For the team to perform at its best it needs to be abreast of all the new information about the development in the organisation and the goal assigned to them. Technological support in this case can be provided to the team so as to ensure their exposure to latest developments.

- vi) **Ensure that the team meets regularly:** This is important not only to ensure that the team regularly works towards achievement of its objective but also to develop rapport and a sense of cohesiveness amongst the team members. The more time they spend together the more they will be able to understand and work effectively with each other.
- vii) **Providing training:** After the team has been constituted some kind of an orientation and training programme can be organised for the members in order to provide them with better idea about the task on hand, facilities available and expected performance.
- viii) **Provide support:** Ensure that adequate support is available to the team from the management and the organisation as a whole for them to work effectively.
- ix) **Give positive feedback:** The management should regularly monitor the performance of the team and provide feedback.
- x) **Reward high performance:** Ensure that high performance by the team is always rewarded. This encourages the team members to perform better and even set higher standards of performance the next time they work on a task.

This will also encourage and set example for other teams to enhance their performance.

Self Assessment Questions

- 1) Differentiate between teams and groups.

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- 2) Discuss various activities carried out by teams.

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- 3) How do we create a high performance team?

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2.3 TEAM WORK

Team work occurs when the members of a team work together and utilise their individual skills to achieve a common goal. In this process the team members also support each other and contribute collectively to the task and achievement of the goals. The goal assigned to the team has to be clear and specific. If the goal is vague then it is not possible for the team members to work collectively towards achieving it. Thus suitable care needs to be taken by the team leader or the management in an organisation to see to it that the goal is clearly understood by the team members.

For team work to be successful and goals to be achieved, proper planning and suitable coordination amongst the members is of utmost importance. Each member should be aware about the task he/ she is supposed to take up.

Suitable planning is to be carried out about the way goal will be achieved and the steps involved and all the team members should be made aware about the plan. Smooth and open communication amongst the team members will enhance the team work and facilitate achievement of team goal.

Each member in the team should be aware about his/her role in the team. Any role ambiguity will lead to ineffective team work. The role played by the leader is very important as he/ she is the one who will have complete knowledge about the team goal and has to accordingly distribute tasks to each member, carry out planning, coordinate the activities of the team and create conducive environment for the team members to function.

All the members in the team are interdependent and thus have to collectively carry out their work. This awareness about interdependence and readiness to be supportive and cooperative are extremely important for the success of team work.

A team should consist of 4 to 12 members. A larger size will negatively impact the planning, coordination and communication amongst the team members. Thus the size of the team should be suitably maintained in order to enhance team work.

A leader also plays an extremely significant role in the team in terms of setting team goals, planning and coordinating team activities, ensuring active participation of members and promoting cohesiveness in the team. The leader has to display suitable leadership skills that will enhance team work.

It is also important for the team leader to know his own strengths and how those strengths can help the entire group. He/ she should share power and information in order to empower team members and reach goals. They also have the responsibility to enable members to find answers for themselves asking questions and encouraging balanced participation. Most important the leader should accept the concept of continuous on- the- learning.

In order to ensure smooth functioning of team and achievement of its goals the team leaders should assign the right people to the right task, maintain diversity in the team in terms of skills and knowledge. They should focus on the interpersonal relationship and communication among team members and make expectations clear.

The team leaders are also responsible to administer rewards and positive reinforcement to the team members and play a crucial role in removing road blocks and obstacles that keep the team from performing.

The team leader while dealing with the team members should remember that each

member has something to add to his/ her team. They also need to fix goals that are measurable to keep your team focused. They should always reward merit, but never let errors go unmarked. They should ensure a degree of independence is essential in successful team work.

Delegation, openness of conduct and communication and a free exchange should be encouraged. They should react positively to novel and creative ideas. A team leader should also understand the strengths, weaknesses of his/ her team members. He/ she should carry out regular performance evaluation and provide suitable feedback.

2.3.1 Problems Affecting Team Work

The problems affecting teams can be broadly classified in to six categories, namely, (i) goals, (ii) team members, (iii) norms, (iv) decision making, (v) leadership and (vi) size. The problems listed below can be categorised under one or more of the above six broad categories.

- i) **Changing Composition:** Change in compositions of the team like transfers, changes, additions of members can affect the functioning of the team. As the team develops through various stages as discussed above, the members develop a rapport and interpersonal relationship with each other. If the composition of team changes frequently, new members are added or old members are transferred, the cohesiveness amongst the team members will be hampered leading to disruption in functioning of the team and delay in the achievement of team goal.
- ii) **Interpersonal relationship among members:** Problems can occur amongst team members if they lack suitable positive interpersonal relationship with each other. Team members in conflict with each other are not only going to negatively impact the team cohesiveness but will also change the team focus to the conflict rather than the task.
- iii) **Communication barriers:** Lack of open and smooth communication between the team members can interfere with the achievement of the team goals. Communication barriers can also occur due to language and cultural differences amongst the members.
- iv) **Social loafing:** Social loafing occurs when certain member of a team does not put in his/her best, thus affecting team activity and team morale at the same time. The team members might feel that the tasks in a team are not equally divided.
- v) **Inappropriate leadership style/ ineffective leader:** A leader plays an extremely important role in any team as he/ she is the person who carries out the planning and coordinates amongst the team members. Thus an ineffective leader or an inappropriate leadership style will interfere with the effective performance of the team.
- vi) **Large size of the team:** If the size of the team is very big it would be difficult for the team members to coordinate and communicate with each other leading to chaos. Thus depending on the task, a suitable size for the team needs to be decided which preferably should be below 12.
- vii) **Role ambiguity:** If the team members are not clear about the role they play in the team, then it would not be possible for them to function effectively.
- viii) **Lack of trust:** It is important that at an early stage of team development the team members develop rapport and positive interpersonal relationship with each

other that will promote development of trust. Lack of trust amongst members will avoid them from sharing information and knowledge with each other and negatively impact their functioning.

- ix) **Domination by one or more members:** The team leader needs to ensure that each member effectively contributes to the functioning of the team at the same time each member has an opportunity to express himself/ herself in the team and contributes to the decision making or problem solving process. Domination by one or members will lead to lowering of morale and motivation amongst other team members as they might feel that their suggestion and view points have not been considered.
- x) **Lack of motivation:** Lack of motivation on part of the team members will disrupt the performance of the team members. Thus the motivation of the team members should be boosted by regular feedbacks rewards etc.
- xi) **Disagreement over team's purpose and tasks:** Arguments and disagreements amongst team members over the team goals and the direction of functioning can gravely impair its functioning. This can be minimised by adopting effective strategies of group discussions by the team leader and members.

2.3.2 Enhancing Team Work

For enhancing team work the following have to be considered:

Size: The size of the team plays an important role in enhancing team work. As discussed earlier a team should be between 4-12 members. The size may also depend on the nature of the organisation and the issue on hand or task to be performed. An optimal team size will enhance team work it enhances coordination, planning and communication amongst the team members.

Skills: At least three main skills need to be focused on while selecting members for the team, namely, technical competence, problem solving and interpersonal skills. Individuals with these skills will be able to function better as team members and will be in a better position to achieve team objectives and goals.

Behavioural aspects of the team members: The behavioural aspects of team members is also important in enhancing team work. The team members should be encouraged to speak respectfully to one another about one another, listen without interrupting, express opinions, feelings openly, honestly, to make 'I' statements and not 'You' statements while taking responsibility, ask for help when needed, offer help when possible, make commitments seriously and keep them up, support the team and each other and focus on problem and solutions, not blame and accusations.

Open Communication: To ensure effective performance of the team, open communication should be ensured. This will reduce disintegration of information and enhance team functioning.

Goals: The team goals should be specific and clear and these goals should be clearly communicated to the team members. Further performance standards should also be set as per the potentialities of the individual members of the team.

Shared leadership: As far as possible shared leadership should be adopted, as it will give opportunity to each and every member to act as a leader. This will also lead to increase in morale of employees and lead to their individual growth.

Decisions/ solutions based on consensus: A team works collectively towards

decision making and problem solving. It is quite possible that members come up with varied and different solutions. The ultimate decision and solution should be based on consensus so as to promote the feeling of cohesiveness amongst the team members. The leader plays a crucial role in ensuring this.

Supportive environment: The organisation and the managers should ensure supportive environment for the team to function at its optimal level.

Stress management: Any stress amongst team members should be identified and managed, as stress can interfere with effective functioning of the team. Yoga, meditation, rational emotive behaviour therapy, relaxation techniques and other techniques can be used in order to help employees deal with stress. An employee counsellor may also be appointed by the organisation in order to help employees cope with their personal and work problems.

Training: Suitable training with regard to both skills and knowledge etc. should be regularly provided. Training can be related to technical or interpersonal skills or with regard to a technological advancement in the organisation. Various methods and modes of training programmes can be utilised.

Self Assessment Questions

1) Explain the concept of team work.

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2) Discuss any two problems affecting team work.

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3) Highlight any three ways of enhancing team work.

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2.4 TEAM INTERVENTION STRATEGIES

As we have seen earlier there are various problems that can clog the activities of the team and measures need to be taken by the management in order to ensure high performance amongst team members. In this regard, certain team intervention strategies can be used by the management or team leaders to enhance the functioning of the teams or reduce conflict amongst the members. These interventions can be directed either at family groups or special groups.

- i) **Role Analysis Techniques [RAT]:** This technique is mainly used to clarify the role obligations of each team member, understanding expectations of team members. The techniques consists of structured series of meetings, listing specific duties and responsibilities, listing the expectations from others and learning what others expect from the individual. A written summary of the whole discussion is also maintained. The technique is especially useful for newly formed teams and teams with role ambiguity.
- ii) **Family Group Diagnostic Meeting:** The purpose of this is to identify team's problems, but not to solve them. The meeting is normally scheduled away from the work situation. A lot of preparation needs to be carried out prior to the meeting in order to understand the nature of the team and goal assigned to them. Further at the meeting, diagnostic information is shared, problem area identified and discussed and attempts are made to generate preliminary action plan. This technique is mainly useful to find out the cause of any problem and to come up with a preliminary action plan.
- iii) **Family Group Team Building Meeting:** This is mainly used to improve team effectiveness in order to solve the problem. It may last for 2-3 days. It involves a series of meetings to ensure that the intended changes take place and remain stable overtime and can be used with both family and special groups. It is useful to ensure stability of a group, improve effectiveness and maintain the team cohesiveness.

Self Assessment Questions

- 1) Discuss Role Analysis Techniques as a team intervention strategy.

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- 2) Explain the concept of Family Group Diagnostic Meeting.

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2.5 LET US SUM UP

Thus in the above unit we discussed about what is a team and team work. We also discussed about the activities of a team and the barriers that can affect team performance. We further highlighted ways of enhancing team work and discussed team intervention strategies. A team thus is an important tool that can be used by organisations to carry out varied functions accurately and efficiently. However, care should be taken while constituting a team and once the team is constituted measure to ensure its effective functioning also needs to be carried out. If this is taken care of then a team serves as an effective mode to ensure organisational development.

2.6 UNIT END QUESTIONS

- 1) Describe team and team work and explain their significance in organisations.
- 2) Highlight the stages of team development.
- 3) Discuss various activities performed by a team.
- 4) Explain various types of teams.
- 5) Discuss in detail the characteristics of high performing teams.
- 6) Explain various barriers to effective team work and suggest suitable solutions to enhance teamwork.

2.7 SUGGESTED READINGS

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UNIT 3 PARALLEL LEARNING STRUCTURES

Structure

- 3.0 Introduction
- 3.1 Objectives
- 3.2 Organisational Learning
 - 3.2.1 System Thinking
 - 3.2.2 Team Learning
 - 3.2.3 Shared Vision
 - 3.2.4 Mental Models
 - 3.2.5 Personal Mastery
 - 3.2.6 Strategies for Organisational Learning
- 3.3 Parallel Learning Structures
 - 3.3.1 Shared Area of Interest
 - 3.3.2 Community
 - 3.3.3 Practice
 - 3.3.4 Features of Parallel Learning Structures
 - 3.3.5 Encouraging Development of Parallel Learning Structures
- 3.4 Let Us Sum Up
- 3.5 Unit End Questions
- 3.6 Suggested Readings

3.0 INTRODUCTION

In the present unit, initially we will try to understand the term organisational learning, which is basic to understanding parallel learning strategies. Further we will discuss the concept of parallel learning structures and try to understand the significance of these structures in organisational context. The unit will highlight features of such structures and also discuss ways of promoting their development in the organisation.

3.1 OBJECTIVES

After completing this unit, you will be able to:

- Define organisational learning;
- Describe characteristic features of organisational learning;
- Explain parallel learning structures;
- Describe the features of parallel learning structures; and
- Analyse the ways of developing parallel learning structures.

3.2 ORGANISATIONAL LEARNING

Learning can take place at individual level, team level or at organisational level. Though we mainly focus and relate learning to an individual, more and more organisations are adopting the concept of organisational learning in order to survive in the competitive world.

Organisational learning can be described as the ability of an organisation to develop an understanding and gain insight from experience through experimentation, observation and analysis and thus make it more efficient and effective in competition to other organisations.

Organisational learning thus studies models and theories about the way an organisation learns and adapts. Effective organisational learning entails modifying the procedure themselves and may be even the assumptions, values, and objectives on which they were based to not only solve current problems, but to prevent their recurrence in the future (Coffey et al, 1997).

It not only contributes to resolving organisational issues, but promotes individual development of knowledge and skills. Organisational learning is also related to organisational change as it can contribute and is conducive to organisational change.

An organisation in the process of learning may utilise any one of the three learning styles, viz., (i) single loop learning, (ii) double loop learning and (iii) deuteron learning.

- i) Single loop learning mainly deals with the identification and rectification of errors. This is the fundamental level of organisational learning where the effectiveness of rules and policies in the organisation are focused on. One disadvantage of this style is that, the organisations may focus only on the errors and not on developmental aspects. This style can be most effective when solving problems with high level of urgency.
- ii) Double loop learning when compared to single loop learning is in-depth. It is normally used in an organisation when there is a need to focus on norms, structures and identify the root causes of an error. The use of this learning style may lead to certain changes that may impact the values, beliefs and strategies in an organisation.

Double loop learning directly deals with the root cause of the problem thus may require a long period of time and cannot be utilised for dealing with immediate problems. Double loop learning is definitely more advantageous to any organisation compared to single loop learning. However, there is hesitation on part of the organisations to use it because of its complexity, time consuming process and also because it involves disclosure of errors and questioning of values, beliefs and strategies in an organisation.

- iii) In deuteron learning, not only there is an in-depth analysis of error and questioning of values, beliefs and strategies as in double loop learning, but it goes one step further and also attempts to evaluate and analyse the whole process of learning. This style thus enhances the learning practice in the organisation.

The above are the three learning styles that might be adopted in an organisation. However, it is not that only a single style is utilised. A successful organisation will apply each of these learning styles depending on the demands of the situation.

Organisational learning is based on five core areas, namely, system thinking, team learning, shared vision, mental models and personal mastery. Of these five areas, system thinking is the most important. These five core areas also distinguish a learning organisation from a bureaucratic organisation.

3.2.1 System Thinking

System thinking is like looking at the organisation as a whole and then focusing on the relationship between its varied parts. It helps in working along with the system rather than against it. In order to develop system thinking, the employees in an organisation need to participate actively in the varied activities taking place in the organisation. System thinking lies at the heart of organisational learning because all the members of the organisation are able to develop an understanding of the whole rather than parts of the organisation like structure, processes and behaviour.

3.2.2 Team Learning

Various types of team exist in organisations that are crucial to the overall functioning of the organisation. Thus it can be said that teams are fundamental units of an organisation and form basic learning units of an organisation.

Team learning occurs when the team members develop a feeling of cohesiveness and collectively experience productiveness while working on a particular task. It involves sharing of knowledge and application of this knowledge in collective thinking environment. For team learning to take place it is extremely important that the team members are involved in effective team behaviour and team work. Further, effective interaction between the team members is extremely important for the team learning to take place and to overcome the barriers that interferes with learning.

3.2.3 Shared Vision

Shared vision means that all the employees in an organisation have common objectives and goals, and they are collectively committed to achieving them. Shared vision is extremely important in an organisation as it sets a performance standard against which each employee can compare his/ her contribution to the organisational goal. Shared vision also develops a feeling of cohesiveness amongst employees and may enhance organisational citizenship. However, in the process of developing a shared vision, it is important to take into consideration the mental models existing in that particular organisation. The employees should also be encouraged to express their personal vision that can form basis of the shared vision. Care must also be taken to evaluate the shared vision on regular basis.

3.2.4 Mental Models

Mental models determine our perception about the world and they are formed in order to help us look at the world in a simple manner. In an organisational set up mental models guide the way in which employees perceive the organisational structures and its processes. It is thus extremely important for an organisation to focus and be aware about the mental models of its employees, as mental models may limit the perception of the employees and stop them from being creative and innovative and may compel them to perceive things from a single perspective. Thus the existing mental model in the organisation needs to be identified and challenged if necessary. Further, a shared mental model may also be developed in an organisation.

3.2.5 Personal Mastery

Personal mastery occurs when an employee is committed to self and professional development and involved in enhancement of his/ her learning skills and competencies. An organisation should encourage development of personal mastery amongst its employees by providing them with training and development programmes, coaching,

mentoring and other facilities. Personal mastery is relevant at all hierarchical levels in an organisation and every employee should be able to develop it in order to enhance organisation learning.

3.2.6 Strategies for Organisational Learning

Varied strategies are employed to promote organisational learning. They are as follows:

- i) **Action learning:** It is process carried out by a group of people with different levels of skills and experience to analyse a real problem and develop an action plan. Learning here takes place by actually working on the problem or carrying out the problem related work activity. The group also supervises the implementation of the action plan and may make changes throughout the implementation process. This strategy is mainly used to deal with complex problems, to identify root cause of the problem and derive a suitable solution and to develop new strategic plans and increase developmental opportunities.

- ii) **Cross-functional teams:** It is composed of people with varied levels of skills and experience who are brought together to accomplish a task.

Cross functional teams help deal with an impending problem in organisations referred to as ‘functional silos problem’, that occurs when the employees in an organisation focus only on the matters concerning their department or function and interact minimally with other departments or units in the organisation. This leads to effective functioning of a single department but not of the organisation as a whole as there is no much communication and coordination between the different departments and units of the organisation.

With the help of cross functional teams, employees from different departments or units come together, interact, discuss and share their point of view with regard to a particular issue or problem. This not only provides with a number of alternatives for dealing with a single issue but also enhances organisational learning as the employees with varied skills, knowledge and expertise are involved in sharing and learning from each other. They may also use action learning as one of their strategies.

- iii) **Work-outs:** These are meetings of employees representing all levels and functions of the organisation or unit, except management, to identify ways the organisation can work together more efficiently and effectively. Work outs can be effectively used to facilitate organisational change and to ensure active participation of all employees in change process, to develop creative and practical strategies of dealing with varied problems in an organisation. It can also be used to redesign work practices and processes.
- iv) **Groupware:** It is technology used to facilitate a group’s communication, problem-solving, and decision-making processes. The group members here may come from different geographical locations. It is extremely useful as it makes communication effective and fast thus accelerating the problem solving and decision making process.
- v) **Benchmarking:** It is a process through which the performance, best practices and achievements of other organisations are compared with one’s own organisation. It can be mainly used to identify the areas in an organisation where improvements can be carried out. It also helps an organisation learn from the performance and achievements of other organisations.

- vi) **Parallel learning structures:** Also known as communities of practice, parallel learning structures, promotes innovation and change in large bureaucratic organisations while retaining the advantages of bureaucratic design. These structures are also effective in bringing about organisational change.

All the above strategies are similar as they promote organisational learning. They differ however in their processes and practices.

Self Assessment Questions

- 1) Describe the concept of organisational learning.

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- 2) Explain the any two core areas of organisational learning.

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- 3) Discuss action learning and work-outs as strategies of organisational learning.

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3.3 PARALLEL LEARNING STRUCTURES

Parallel Learning Structures may be a form of Knowledge Management. Knowledge Management involves capturing the organisation's collective expertise wherever it resides (in databases, on paper, or in people's heads) and distributing it to the people who need it in time. They promote innovation and change in large bureaucratic organisations while retaining the advantages of bureaucratic design. It is also referred to as communities of practice.

Though recently coined the practice has been around for since a very long time. It is widely used in various organisations in order to promote learning and development because knowledge is viewed as a critical asset that requires suitable management. Parallel learning strategies focus on people and on the social structures that enable them to learn with and from each other.

The concept of Parallel Learning Structures was first introduced by Dale and Zand in 1974 under the label Collateral Organisations. They described it as a supplemental organisations existing with usual formal organisations, which are mainly useful to deal with structural problems that the formal organisation is unable to deal with.

These structures are modes of learning how to change the structure and leading the whole change process. It can also be described as a structure or a coordination of

employees that emerges or is created parallel to the formal structure of the organisation, which can be beneficial in promoting organisational learning, encouraging innovation and creativity and their implementation amongst the employees.

Parallel Learning Structures consists of a steering committee and number of working groups that study changes that need to be made, make suggestions for improvement and monitor the change process. The steering committee might also be supported by idea or action groups.

There are three important elements of parallel learning structures namely, shared area of interest, community and practice.

3.3.1 Shared Area of Interest

The members of the group involved in parallel learning structure necessarily have a shared area of interest and the members are committed to this interest. This area of interest can be a problem, an issue requiring decision making. The group members have collective competence in dealing with the shared area of interest and they learn from each other in the process.

3.3.2 Community

The members of the group engage in activities and sharing of knowledge and information in the process of dealing with shared area of interest. It might not be necessary for the members to interact on daily basis. An interpersonal relationship develops between the members and they involve in give and take of ideas and information. They interact and learn together as one community.

3.3.3 Practice

The group members share information and ideas about the issue or area of interest and are able to identify certain solutions. They develop a shared gamut of resources, experiences, stories, tools, and ways of addressing recurring problems that can also be referred as shared practice. This may take time and sustained interaction.

The parallel learning strategies are a combination of the above three elements. These structures are valuable to both individuals and organisations. The individual members greatly benefit from these structures especially when they come across a particular problem and need some kind of assistance dealing with it. In such a situation they have an easy access to expertise and help from other members. Thus they are able to deal effectively with the problem within a short period of time.

The individuals also benefit from the sharing of knowledge and may develop expertise in this process. Overall the individuals in parallel learning structures are found to be highly motivated towards learning and self development. This also has a positive impact on their performance and productivity in the organisation.

At organisational level, such structures are extremely significant not only because it leads to individual development of the employees in the organisation, but also because it leads to overall development of the organisation and achievement of its goals.

Parallel learning structures are useful when the organisation needs the employees to be creative and innovative in their approach to work, promote the give and take of knowledge and information amongst the employees in the organisation and to enhance and utilise the collective expertise of the organisation.

An organisational culture with continuous learning is created and developed with the help of such structures. The younger and newer employees in the organisation also benefit through sharing with certain senior employees in the organisation and able to adjust to the new situation in better manner. The members develop a sense of identity and become more participative and empowered.

Parallel learning structures can be compared with two other groups commonly found in organisational set up, namely, interest groups and project teams. Parallel learning structures are similar at the same time different from these two groups in various ways.

An interest group is a group of employees taking interest and working on an issue or a problem and a project team is a team constituted to achieve a particular goal.

The similarities between these three types of groups are that they are face to face or virtual, in either case there is a continuous and consistent interaction taking place between the members.

With regard to the differences, the goal of parallel learning structures and interest groups is knowledge sharing and knowledge creation where as project teams mainly deal with tasks and projects. Parallel learning structures and interest groups have a culture of learning, are spontaneous, voluntary, informal and may have short or long lifespan, where as project teams have a culture of action, are intentional, is formal in terms of its administration and is constituted for a limited period of time.

The structure of parallel learning structures is homogeneous, on the other hand the interest groups and project teams have a heterogeneous structure. With regard to membership, parallel learning structures have core and voluntary members, interest groups have an open membership, where as project teams have membership as a result of assignment. The parallel learning structures focus on same topic, problems and interests and this is the main reason that the structures emerge. Interest groups focus on mixed topics, different problems but same interest and project teams focus on deliverables.

Thus it can be noticed that though the three groups do have lots of similarities, they do differ mainly in terms of their focus.

3.3.4 Features of Parallel Learning Structures

Though parallel learning structures may vary from organisation to organisation, they do possess certain common features. These features are discussed as follows:

- i) **Sharing of Knowledge:** One of the main features of parallel learning structures is sharing of knowledge and information amongst the members of its groups. The knowledge is shared through discussions, interactions and participation. This kind of sharing helps the members become more aware of the issues in an organisation and also help them come up with effective solutions.
- ii) **Spontaneous:** Most parallel learning structures emerge spontaneously without any efforts on behalf of the organisation, as the members get together voluntarily. It is however beneficial for organisations to promote growth of such structures for successful sharing of knowledge and effective resolution of certain issues.
- iii) **Common Objective:** Most commonly parallel learning structures emerge as a result of a group of people with common objective or interest or shared vision coming together. These people in an informal set up start sharing knowledge with regard to their common concern. These individuals may also have a common

set of values and beliefs. Though the group members might not work together or meet regularly there is a consistent sharing of knowledge that takes place between them. The members may also share equal passion and commitment towards the common issue which enhances the overall functioning of the structure. The group members may interact with each other either face to face or virtually. Technological advancement can facilitate development of such structures and enhance their overall functioning.

- iv) **Informal nature:** As the emergence of these structures is spontaneous, the groups are informal in nature thus creating a conducive environment for interaction and give and take of knowledge. These informal networks in an organisation facilitate faster and better accomplishments of tasks and effective problem solving and decision making. These informal networks may later be formally incorporated into the organisational structure.
- v) **Formal guidance:** Though these structures emerge spontaneously and are informal in nature. The overall functioning of these structures can be enhanced if they receive formal guidance from the management and the organisation. It is not only important for the organisation to formalize certain structures that greatly contribute to the resolution of issues and overall development of the organisation, but also to provide guidance and direction for the structures and its members to work.
- vi) **Size of the structure:** The size of different structures will vary depending on the shared issue. The size can range from few members to more than hundred members. The size will also determine the activities and practices of structures.
- vii) **Lifespan:** The life span of the structure will again vary depending on the common objective, activities and practices of the structures. Thus the lifespan may be short or long. The lifespan will also depend on the trust and support amongst the members and whether the structure is informal or formalised.
- viii) **Leader:** A leader of a particular structure plays an extremely significant role in the functioning of the structure. The leader serves as a bridge between the structure and organisation besides ensuring smooth sharing of knowledge and focus on the shared objective. The leader may be one of the most respected and influential members of the structure.

3.3.5 Encouraging Development of Parallel Learning Structures

The organisations need to be aware and identify the informal interactions that naturally occur amongst the employees, as it might not be possible for an organisation to initiate a particular structure. But they can definitely create conducive environment for such structures to develop and flourish in the organisation.

The organisations should also develop an understanding of what a parallel learning structure is. They need to understand that these structures are informal and spontaneous in nature and may exist across department and hierarchies and boundaries in same organisation.

It is also important that these informal structures are identified by the organisation and provided with suitable guidance, direction and environment. But it should also be ensured that there is no interference on behalf of the organisation in the overall functioning of these structures.

Organisations need to promote trust, open communication, mutual understanding and support to foster successful development of such communities. An interaction format may also be developed by the organisation and adequate time should be provided for social interaction between the employees.

The organisations need to distinguish between sharing of information and sharing of knowledge. Sharing of information via emails, notices, minutes of meetings and other modes is not at same level as sharing of knowledge which occurs at a deeper level where the insights and analysis of any information is shared.

The organisations may also promote technological advancements in order to enhance development and functioning of parallel learning structures.

The organisation may offer incentives and rewards for the contributions of parallel learning structures. This will encourage further growth of such structures and emergence of new ones. The basis of such rewards can be innovation, creativity or spontaneity.

Self Assessment Questions

1) Define and describe parallel learning structures.

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2) Discuss various elements of parallel learning structures.

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3) Explain any three features of parallel learning structures.

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4) How do you encourage development of parallel learning structures?

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3.4 LET US SUM UP

Parallel learning structures are everywhere, in schools, universities, in sports, at work etc. They are about people and are of great benefit to its members and the organisation. They can be described as groups of people who share a common interest and

concern. They enhance the sharing of knowledge and information and also provide quick solutions to complex problems. It is thus extremely important for an organisation to identify the parallel learning structures within its environment as it can contribute greatly to the overall development of the organisation.. But it is important to focus on these structures and guide their development without too much of interference on part of the organisation and management. Their presence in an organisation enhances organisational learning and change and they also contribute to the knowledge management process in an organisation.

3.5 UNIT END QUESTIONS

- 1) Explain the concept of organisational learning and its core areas.
- 2) Describe various strategies of organisational learning.
- 3) Describe parallel learning structures and highlight its features.
- 4) Discuss how development of parallel learning structures can be encouraged in an organisation.

3.6 SUGGESTED READINGS

Al-Hawamdeh, Suliman.(2003). *Knowledge Management*. Oxford. Chandos Publishing Limited.

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UNIT 4 A NORMATIVE RE-EDUCATIVE STRATEGY FOR CHANGE

Structure

- 4.0 Introduction
- 4.1 Objectives
- 4.2 Organisational Change
- 4.3 Resistance to Change
 - 4.3.1 Resistance as a System Variable
- 4.4 Strategies to Overcome Resistance to Change
 - 4.4.1 Action Centered Approach
 - 4.4.2 Rational Empirical Approach
 - 4.4.3 Normative Re-educative Approach
 - 4.4.4 The Power Coercive Approach
 - 4.4.5 Common Assumptions of a Power Coercive Approach to Change
 - 4.4.6 Political/Positional Power as a Change Strategy
 - 4.4.7 Economic Power as a Change Strategy
 - 4.4.8 Environment Adaptive Strategy
- 4.5 A Normative Re- educative Strategy for Change
 - 4.5.1 Assumptions of Normative Re-educative Strategy for Change
 - 4.5.2 Factors to be Considered while Applying Normative Re-Educative Strategy
 - 4.5.3 Implications of Normative Re-educative Strategy
 - 4.5.4 Sub Strategies for Normative Re-educative Strategies
- 4.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 4.7 Unit End Questions
- 4.8 Suggested Readings

4.0 INTRODUCTION

In this unit we will discuss the concept of organisational change and various approaches to organisational change. It will further highlight normative re-educative strategy as one of the approaches to change. It will then explain the factors of implementing this strategy. The applications and implications of this strategy will also be highlighted. Further sub- strategies for this approach will also be explained.

4.1 OBJECTIVES

After completing this unit, you will be able to:

- Define organisational change;
- Describe the characteristic features of organisation change;
- Explain the various approaches to organisational change;
- Elucidate the normative re educative strategy for change;
- Analyse the factors before implementing the normative re educative strategy;

- Explain the assumptions and implication for the normative re- educative approach; and
- Analyse the sub strategies for the normative re educative approach.

4.2 ORGANISATIONAL CHANGE

Changes are constantly taking place in the environment of organisations. Change can be described as a process of moving from one condition to another. Changes in organisations can occur as a result of varied external and internal forces. Ecological, demographic and cultural changes are some of the external forces that can have an impact on political, economic and technological aspects of change in an organisation.

Changes in policy, structures, technology can be examples of internal changes in an organisation. In order to survive, develop and prosper in this situation, organisations must identify and adapt to these forces.

Organisational Change can be described as a complex process that occurs as a result of interaction between technological, historical, behavioural, social, economic, demographic and political forces.

Change can be planned or unplanned. A planned change occurs spontaneously, where as an unplanned change is intentional and planned by the management. Introduction of new safety devices or technological advancement can be an example of planned change introduced by an organisation.

High turnover, absenteeism, communication and decision making breakdown can be examples of unplanned changes.

The timing and manner in which changes are introduced in an organisation have a lot to do with how successful they are. They can be introduced effectively when factors that would be conducive to their acceptance and those that provoke employees to resist them are first identified. Once this is done change could be introduced in various ways (Sekaran, 2008).

Both people and organisations resist change though it might be in the best of their interest. Change can have an adverse effect on the motivation, morale and the overall performance of the employees. It can lead to increase in absenteeism, high errors and low productivity.

Organisational change can also be categorised as:

- i) radical change also called as frame breaking change and
- ii) incremental change also called as frame bending change.

Radical change can be explained as a change that leads to major refurbish of an organisation or its systems. Incremental change on the other hand is a part of the organisation's natural development.

4.3 RESISTANCE TO CHANGE

Resistance to change is functional when not carried to extremes. In other words, the energy we put into resisting change also permits us to *preserve balance* in our lives by relegating habitual responses to the unconscious. Two key components of resistance are (i) selective perception and (ii) selective retention.

These help us organise our understandings of our environment.

As we grow up, we learn to depend on others' expertise in various roles that is of parents, teachers, doctors, sports coaches and so on. Basically, society teaches us to accept the status quo. This leads to self-distrust in the face of potential change ("I shouldn't") and even to regression (as in reverting to old, familiar practices in new situations). All of these, of course, are processes to which the coach/consultant would be as readily subject as the client. Yet resistance is almost always discussed in the context of client behaviour.

There are theories of resistance in *social systems* and resistance in *individuals*. Attempts to eliminate resistance, therefore, tend to focus on the *targets* of change. If team members are resisting their manager's directives, for example, we might facilitate group meetings where we communicate the need for change and encourage group plans to enact the change. In doing this we might use joint diagnosis and consensus building to reduce feelings of threat, to engage peoples' interest, to help them feel the project is at least somewhat their own, and try to make it fit their values and ideals. We search for the key "defenders" of the status quo and try to enlist their support for the change effort by taking their concerns seriously as given in the box below:

What are the threats to their well-being?

What might be dysfunctional about the proposed change that we've overlooked?

What have we not yet understood about the sources of their mistrust?

In order to overcome resistance we should observe even subtle differences between our perceptions and those of our clients. We should appreciate the importance of understanding clients' values and sources of identification and of determining where our values are likely to fit, rather than vice versa. We are less likely to forget that difficulties in a change effort may stem from our own assumptions about what clients need.

4.3.1 Resistance as a System Variable

Lewin's *force-field analysis* is the most commonly used model to illustrate elements of change and resistance to change:

According to Lewin's model, pressing for change tends to threaten stability and thus increases the power of forces maintaining the system.

Therefore, the most effective way to bring about change is to *reduce the forces of resistance*. This implies, however, that resistance exists only on one side of the force field. The energy to *restrain* movement toward change and the energy to *move toward* change are treated conceptually as arising from different places. As coaches/consultants, we see ourselves as the "driving forces." Thus theory guides practice when we interpret resistance to change as emanating only from clients ("restraining forces").

Individuals may resist change due to selective perception, lack of information, fear and uncertainty, negative attitude, etc. On the other hand, organisations may resist change to maintain power and structural stability, to avoid risk taking, etc. Therefore organisations have to systematically plan to bring about changes and be constantly aware and alert about certain changes that can occur in the external and internal environment of the organisations.

To overcome resistance to change, organisations:

- 1) They can employ various strategies like open communication with the relevant stake holders like clients, customers, share holders and most importantly employees.
- 2) They can also create awareness regarding the purpose and benefits of change.
- 3) They can provide education with regard to the purpose and benefits of change.
- 4) They can encourage the employees to participate in the decision making related to change.
- 5) They can involve them in the process of change.
- 6) The organisations can also provide support, training, counseling during the process of change in order to deal with the anxieties and uncertainties experienced by the employees.

Managing change in an organisation is a complex activity that requires dealing with varied problems and challenges in the internal and external environment of the organisation. As change is inevitable, it is extremely important that the management and the managers are aware of change and take active role in anticipating, planning, facilitating and implementing change through effective strategies.

Competencies in managing change are required in order to achieve the organisational goal. Various approaches to managing change can be utilised by organisations. These strategies can be selected based on various aspects like

- a) the target population or
- b) the nature of target population,
- c) the type and degree of change and
- d) resistance to change displayed or expected,
- e) time and expertise available to manage change.

4.4 STRATEGIES TO OVERCOME RESISTANCE TO CHANGE

Any of the following strategies can be used depending on the demands of the situation in the organisation.

4.4.1 Action-Centred Approach

This approach is action based and mainly focuses on the problem and possible solution to the problem. It can be described as a process of systematically collecting data on a particular organisation. The data collected is then passed on to the management or the relevant authorities who utilise the data to draw an action plan. The results of the action plan are then evaluated and more data might accordingly be collected by repeating the process as necessary. The steps involved in this approach include:

- 1) preliminary diagnosis,
- 2) collection of data,

- 3) feedback about the data,
- 4) development of action plan,
- 5) implementation of action plan and
- 6) evaluation and follow up.

This approach is utilised as and when a performance gap is identified.

One especially useful, if perhaps excessively academic, roundup of “General Strategies for Effecting Changes in Human Systems” is provided by Robert Chin and Kenneth Benne in their classic textbook *The Planning of Change*. In their analysis, change strategies fall into three categories:

- 1) rational-empirical, 2) normative- re-educative, and 3) power-coercive.

4.4.2 Rational Empirical Approach

The *rational-empirical* approach assumes that men and women are rational and practical and will change on their own given the appropriate conditions. These strategies include:

- 1) Provide the right information, education or training to allow individuals to change of their own volition.
- 2) Ensure that the “right” people are in the right “place” to bring about needed changes.
- 3) Invite the perspectives or expertise of outsiders.
- 4) Engage in research and development.
- 5) Promote utopian thinking to stimulate creativity and “best-case” scenarios.
- 6) Clarify the issues and/or reconceptualise the situation in order to bring about greater overall understanding among members of the group.

4.4.3 Normative Re-educative Approach

This is being dealt with in detail at the end of this unit. However to state briefly, the second category of strategies, that is the *normative-reeducative approach* is predicated on the view that change begins from the bottom up, not the top down. That is to say, it focuses on changing the individuals that make up a social system. It is the preferred method of counselors, trainers, and therapists. Two strategies characteristic of this approach are to:

- Improve the problem-solving capacities of a system by encouraging individuals to be self-diagnosing.
- Release and foster growth in the persons who make up the system.

4.4.4 The Power-Coercive Approach

This approach to effecting change is the one most commonly associated with political movements and social activism. In the words of Chin and Benne, “these strategies are oriented against coercive and nonreciprocal influence, both on moral and on pragmatic grounds.” Strategies in this category include:

- Using political institutions to achieve change.
- Shifting the balance of power between social groups, especially ruling elites.

- Weakening or dividing the opposition through moral coercion or strategies of nonviolence.

Another taxonomy of change strategies is offered by Roland Warren, a sociologist who has devoted much attention to social change at the community level. His list of community based change strategies include: consensus planning, bargaining, protest movements, research- demonstrations, social action, non-violence, organisations of client populations, community development, conflict, elite planning, organisation of indigenous groups, and civil disobedience. He classifies these under four headings:

1) collaborative strategies, 2) campaign strategies, 3) contest strategies, and 4) a combination of strategies.

What this literature shows is that there are at bottom two modes of viewing change: the reactive and the proactive. From one perspective, individuals and groups are the objects of change. They are at the receiving end, in the sense that change happens to them. From the other perspective, individuals and groups are the initiators of change and change follows from human volition. Both perspectives have their validity, of course, and they are closely interrelated. For instance, when one social group actively tries to bring about change, there are invariably other groups who feel put upon and try to resist the change.

4.4.5 Common Assumptions of a Power Coercive Approach to Change

- Power is legitimate and carries rights with it. That is people should listen to those who hold power.
- Those with power have the responsibility to give direction to others in the system. It is not significant that those others do not accept the direction that they are receiving as appropriate or correct.
- Those who hold power have the right to punish those who do not follow their directions.
- The best interest of the organisation are served naturally by following the directions of those who are more senior in the hierarchy, that is, naturally they know what is best because of their experience.

Elements of power can be found in all approaches to change as explained below.

In the rational empirical approach power is based in the information or knowledge that is used as a prime mover of change. In this approach, those who possess the knowledge hold power in the system. Judicious use of information represents a clear application of power within the systems change driven by knowledge.

In Normative reeducating change, the underlying philosophy of change focuses on the development of a personal sense of power and the sharing of organisational power through the active involvement of system members in problem definition and solution generation.

The power coercive strategy emphasises a different approach and different elements of the power process. In general, this approach to change emphasises the use of political and economic sanctions as the principle strategy to bringing about change, although the use of 'moral' power also historically forms a key element of the strategy. (Benne & Chin, 1985).

4.4.6 Political / Positional Power as a Change Strategy

Political or positional power involves the ability to create policies, directions, laws and other legal agreements that bring with them legitimate sanctions for non compliance. Threat of sanction has the impact of increasing the willingness of system members to follow the directions of those who hold the power and engage in the change that they mandate. In addition to the economic and other sanctions that tend to be associated with this approach to change, many individuals are influenced by deeply held cultural beliefs concerning the legitimacy of senior members of the hierarchy to give direction to members of the systems for which they hold responsibility. The aura of legitimacy of the power source is sufficient in these cases to reduce resistance to imposed change. In such cases, a power coercive way of making decision is accepted as the nature of the way the system operates.

4.4.7 Economic Power as a Change Strategy

The use of economic sanctions represents a logical extension of political power. Under a political power scenario in the broader social context, sanctions generally focus on jail and other personal liberty sanctions. Under the economic power strategy for change, the rewards (and sanctions) focus on the provision of financial incentives or withholding the incentives. Organisations can differentially reward members for their active implementation of new methods of management or new approaches to dealing with issues.

Specific strategies of power coercive change range from overthrow of political regimes through non violence, the changing of organisational management through stakeholder pressure and the power of the annual meeting, the use of public policy and legislation to force organisational change, and the use of moral persuasion to embarrass management into appropriate action. Classic example of such a strategy is that of Gandhi's efforts to overthrow the British in India. Many different applications of power strategies to force change is available and all are quite effective in their own way.

All of the above meta strategies, namely rational-empirical, normative reeducative, and power coercive represent approaches to bringing about change in human systems.

The *power-coercive* approach is based on *political, economic, and/or moral sanctions* as sources of influence, is widespread in organisations but not particularly valued by change agents. At the furthest extreme, a coercive approach pays little attention to the people, their ideas or their needs. Changes are implemented in a relatively mechanical way

Typical of a coercive approach is the shock and surprise that people encounter as change is thrust upon them. The usual situation is that people arrive at work one Monday morning and find that they no longer have a job. They may alternatively be told that they are going to have to move far away across the country, a tactic sometimes used to legally reduce the workforce. Another variant is to bankrupt the company and then re-start as a new company with everyone having to apply again for their jobs (this has been used to get around Trade Union issues).

Not all coercive approaches are unethical and some are simply born of the need for urgency. Ethics lie in the values of the people who are planning and implementing the change, rather than the fact that a coercive approach is being used.

Thus the coercive approach is one of the approaches that is widely used in

organisations but might not be most effective approaches of managing change. This approach mainly follows an authoritative style, in which there is application of power, sanctions and influence to bring about change. It is based on assumptions that power is legitimate that individual comply with people who have power. The individual with power gives direction that is to be followed by others. These individuals with power have a right to punish those individuals who do not comply with their directions. Thus in a change situation the employees have to follow the directions given by those with authority and accept the change without giving a thought to its significance their context. Though the implementation of this approach is quick, the effect might not be long lasting and will result in low commitment amongst the employees.

As mentioned earlier briefly, the Empirical rational approach believes that employees are rational and therefore need to be provided with relevant information about change and, its benefits to the organisation in general and employees in specific. This approach promotes open communication and awareness about change in order to persuade the employees to accept and facilitate change. This approach is based on assumptions that employees are driven by self interest, if the information with regard to change and its relevance is appropriately put forth in front of the employees they will understand it in a better way and support it. However, the information provided should be accurate. The managers and superiors play an important role in communication of such information. This approach cannot be termed as the most effective approach. However, it can lead to moderate commitment by the employee towards change and the effect might last for some period of time if not permanently.

4.4.8 Environmental Adaptive Strategy

This approach assumes that reaction to change is a natural process as is adaptation to change. Any change in an organisation will meet with negative attitude and reactions by employees, which will lead to gradual adaptation to change. Thus the organisation creates a new environment, once this has been done, the old environment is shut down. The employees then have to adjust to the new environment as no other option is made available.

As discussed earlier, the Normative re educative approach is one very effective approach to deal with change as it focuses on changing the norms, attitudes and values of individuals which in turn will lead to changes in behaviour and performance of the employees. This approach will be discussed in detail in this unit.

There is no single strategy that can be used in varied situations. An eclectic approach is often necessary to deal with each organisational change situation. Various factors need to be taken in to consideration like the degree of change and resistance, the population of the organisation, time limit, nature of the organisation etc. before a particular strategy or strategies are employed. In complex situations, a combination of all strategies can be employed

Self Assessment Questions

1) Explain the concept of organisational change.

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2) What are the various approaches to break resistance to organisational change?

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3) Differentiate between and power coercive and empirical rational approach.

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4) What is meant by eclectic method to break resistance to change?

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4.5 ANORMATIVE RE-EDUCATIVE STRATEGY FOR CHANGE

Normative re-educative strategy is at the core of organisational change. The strategy was introduced by R. Chin and K. Benne. It is also called as shared power strategy. The objective of this strategy is to expose employees to new values and norms and the need to adopt these new values and norms. It is based on rational/ scientific evidence or emotional appeals. This strategy is implemented by focusing mainly on system renewal, people in the organisation. Here it is important to employ an educational strategy with learning through experience as its highlight. The strategy also promotes dealing with real problems by using a planned strategy.

For this strategy to be successfully implemented the organisation needs to identify a change agent at the same time ensure involvement of top-level administration. This strategy is based on the belief that people are social creatures, and cultural norms are core to their group identity. It not only assumes that individuals are rational but gives equal importance to the socio- cultural influences in an organisation.

According to this approach change will occur after the employees involved in bringing about or affected by change are able change their older normative orientations to commit to new orientations related to the change to be implemented in the organisation. Change in this approach is not limited to knowledge, information and intellectual rationales but it also covers attitudes, values, skills and significant relationships.

This strategy mainly focuses on group norms, personal values, and common goals. This is much effective compared to imposing change through authority and coercion. By utilising this approach, change becomes part of the organisational culture and thus receives the support of the social forces and group dynamics in an organisation.

Change can thus be successfully implemented when it is in tandem with existing structures, attitudes, values, and norms in an organisation. The approach promotes collaborative working with the employees to identify problems and facilitate solutions. Its objective is to improve problem-solving capacities and mechanisms within a system, and develop new attitudes, values, skills, and norms for interaction amongst employees. The strategy not only promotes organisational change but also encourages participation and develops empowerment amongst the employees.

Further team work is also promoted as the manager or the superior needs to work together with the employees in order to implement this strategy. It also results in optimal development and application of creativity and experience of the employees within the organisation.

The three main elements of this strategy are attitudes, beliefs and values. Attitudes are feeling and beliefs that determine the way in which employees perceive their environment and behave. It can be described as modes through which employees express their feelings about the organisation, people in it and its structure, processes etc. Employee attitudes are extremely important in an organisation as they might be a reflection of an underlying problem. If not dealt with at right time a negative attitude towards an organisation or its aspects can lead to development of major problems in an organisation.

Positive attitude on the other hand will enhance the overall functioning of an organisation. Attitude plays an extremely important role when it comes to change. Change leads to development of number of insecurities amongst the employees that may lead to development of negative attitude towards change. Thus before change process is initiated, the management needs to identify the presence of any negative attitude and deal with it. Normative re-educative strategy is once such strategy that directly focuses on the employee attitude and this can be termed as key to its successful long term effects in an organisation.

Beliefs can be described as certainty in the truth of a proposition. They are based on experience, perception, communication reasoning etc. In an organisational set up beliefs of an employee are extremely important. The change process may be affected by the beliefs of employees about the change process. Thus beliefs are to be focused on before the change process is initiated.

Values can be described as an individual understands of what is wrong and what is right, good or bad, preferable or not preferable. Values develop early in life and greatly determine an individuals' behaviour. They are also extremely difficult to change. Values of employees are of extreme importance in an organisation as they determine the motivational level, behaviour and attitudes of an employee. In order to enhance the process of change in an organisation, the management needs to examine values of its employees.

Though the strategy is time consuming it is beneficial as it is long lasting and results in internalised change. Despite of these benefits, managers hesitate in using these strategies due to fear of loosing control or shifting focus from organisational goals. Managers do play an important role in implementing this strategy as their willingness to share power and interpersonal skills in terms of interacting, communicating and promoting participation is necessary for the implementation of the strategy to be successful.

4.5.1 Assumptions of Normative Re-educative Strategy for Change

The employees are involved in the process of change and its implementation.

The strategy focuses and promotes shifts in attitudes, values, norms, and relationships amongst employees in order to enhance the process and implementation of change.

Management and employees play equally crucial role and mutually contribute to the change process.

There is no power dominance by the management or any higher authority on the employees during the overall change process.

In depth analysis of the structure, system and processes of the organisation is carried out as apart of the change process. This is done not only to enhance implementation of change in present but also to ensure smooth change process in future.

4.5.2 Factors to be Considered While Applying Normative Re-educative Strategy

Care needs to be taken and factors to be considered, before this strategy is applied so as to ensure its successful implementation. This strategy is largely based on culture. It also takes in to consideration attitudes, values and beliefs of employees in the organisation. It can be extremely difficult to change culture and the whole process takes a long period of time. Thus this strategy will not be effective and should not be selected in situations that demand urgent rectification of problems and issues.

Further organisational culture depends on both formal and informal groups in the organisation. Thus this strategy will be most applicable only when there is a positive cordial and harmonious relationship between the formal and informal groups in the organisation. In case of a conflict situation between formal and informal groups the strategy might be applied only after the conflict is deal with and harmony is reinstated.

Also it is important to focus and be aware about parallel learning structures in the organisation as they can be a key to success of this strategy.

Any change process will have both short term and long term goals. Normative re-educative strategy will fit in well to achieve the long term goals. As this strategy directly focuses on culture in an organisation and attitudes, values and beliefs of an organisation the outcome is almost always positive and long lasting. Further, this strategy is effective when the core issue and problem to be dealt with has its roots either in culture of the organisation or it has to do with attitudes, values and beliefs of the employees.

Managers and other superiors also need to be trained and their attitude is to be deal with before the strategy is implemented. Managers play a crucial role in this case as they are the ones who directly interact with the employees and thus are to a greater extend aware about their attitudes, values and beliefs.

4.5.3 Implications of Normative Re-educative Strategy

Employees in the organisation affected by the change process suggest desired change and improvement rather than the organisational change practitioners or change agent. The employees are given complete control over the change situation that encourages them to come up with suitable solutions for smooth implementation of organisational change.

A collaborative approach is employed, where the employees and change agents discuss problems and seek and suggest solutions. The employees are thus encouraged to employ participative approach and are empowered in the whole process.

Barriers to effective problem solving like negative attitudes, doubts are identified and openly discussed. Such an open discussion not only highlights the barriers and creates awareness amongst the employees but also promotes their effective management.

Solutions to problems are based on attitudes, beliefs, values, relationships rather than technical knowledge and information. This results in long lasting management of problems.

4.5.4 Sub Strategies for Normative Re-educative Strategies

Some of the sub strategies are given below:

- i) **Training Programmes on problem solving and decision making organised for employees in the organisation:** In order to enhance the whole process of normative re-educative strategy, the employees in the organisation are provided with training programmes on problem solving and decision making.
- ii) **Participation encouraged amongst the employees:** Measures are taken to encourage participation amongst the employees. Employees are also encouraged to be innovative and involve in lateral thinking. They are also encouraged to set up challenging tasks and opportunities for employees. Participation is also encouraged in the change process.
- iii) **Gathering and collection of information and data with regard to the system by the employees:** To bring about smooth implementation of change, it is necessary that employees understand the whole organisational system, hence the employees are involved in the process of gathering and collecting information and data so that they not only feel involved in the process of participation but also become aware about the relevance and benefits of implementing change in the organisation. Further change related discussions are also promoted in the organisation.
- iv) **Vertical slice benchmarking:** This involves demonstration of developments across all units or departments of an organisation. This helps the employees understand the performance standards and achievements of the organisation and also make them aware about the need for change.

Self Assessment Questions

- 1) Explain the concept of normative re-educative strategy for change.

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- 2) Highlight assumptions of normative re-educative strategy.

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4.6 LET US SUM UP

Normative Re-educative Strategy believes that employees are social being and are strongly influenced by culture and norms prevalent in the organisation. Thus according to this strategy change can be successfully initiated when culture in organisation is dealt with and norms are redefined and reinterpreted. While applying this strategy the manager or the superior plays an extremely important role. Various factors also need to be taken in to consideration before its application. Though the change process brought about with the help of this strategy might be slow, the results are definitely accurate and long lasting.

4.7 UNIT END QUESTIONS

- 1) Discuss the concept of organisational change and highlight strategies used by organisations to promote organisational change.
- 2) Explain the concept of normative re-educative strategy for change.
- 3) Discuss implication of normative re-educative strategy.
- 4) Highlight the sub strategies of normative re-educative strategy.

4.8 SUGGESTED READINGS

Coffey, R. R., Cook, C.W., & Hunsaker, P.L. (1997). *Management and Organisational Behaviour*, 2nd Ed. New Delhi. McGraw- Hill Companies.

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